

« Sport matters because it allows us to be visible in a country where public spaces remain largely inaccessible »

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Everyone has their own motivation for performing at the Para Athletics World Championships in New Delhi.

For me, one reason is deeply personal: it's my first chance to compete at a World Championships in India. I've already been to four editions abroad, but this one feels different.

It's one thing to do well overseas and another to do well at home, with family and friends cheering — in Hindi, no less!

But my journey to this stage didn't begin with sport.

I was paralysed in a car accident at 18. After the injury, my first priority was academics. I wanted financial independence. In 2014, I cleared the Haryana State civil services exam, a turning point in my life. It challenged many perceptions — I proved that women with disabilities could be independent,

earn a living, and support themselves.

That was when Amit Saroha, one of the pioneers of para sport in India, noticed me through a newspaper interview. He introduced me to athletics. At first, I doubted myself, but my parents convinced me to give it a try. Their reasoning was simple: I already had a job, so there was nothing to lose. Sport could at least help me focus on my health. Once I began winning medals, there was no looking back.

I enjoy winning, of course, but more than that, I love the training

and the chance to be outdoors. For most persons with disabilities in India, public spaces remain inaccessible. Often, we are confined to our homes. Sport gives us a rare opportunity to step outside, breathe fresh air, and be visible in a society that too often hides us away. That's why the accessibility upgrades at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium matter so much, even if there is still a long way to go.

My first big stage was the Tokyo Paralympics, though I couldn't perform to my potential there. I looked forward to Paris 2024, but my



The hardest struggle is not training — it's changing mindsets. People with disabilities are still not seen as part of the mainstream.